

HTCS6704 Assignment 1:

Case Study Report

By Luis Suarez, Akshay Pragji, Young kwang Kweon

Executive Summary

This report investigates the cybersecurity risks highlighted by the 2023 Latitude Financial breach that affected New Zealand and Australia, where more than 14 million records, including driver's licences and passports, were compromised. This incident highlights the critical importance of aligning cybersecurity practices with business objectives, legal obligations, and ethical responsibilities.

The purpose of this investigation is to demonstrate how New Zealand enterprises can adopt the Enterprise Security Risk Management (ESRM) model, a business-driven process for managing risks to improve risk governance and resilience through four steps: identifying and prioritising critical assets, assessing risks, developing mitigation strategies, and continuous improvement.

Our key findings revealed that Latitude Financial failed to effectively manage sensitive customer data, allowed excessive retention of personal information, and lacked adequate access controls and monitoring. Governance oversight was insufficient, reflecting a broader issue across New Zealand enterprises where boards underestimate cyber risks. Ethical considerations, guided by the ITP Code of Ethics, show that Latitude also fell short in protecting privacy, acting with integrity, and communicating transparently with affected customers.

By applying ESRM alongside ethical practices, it will enable enterprises to align cybersecurity with organisational goals, comply with regulatory obligations such as the Privacy Act 2020, and build resilience against future attacks.

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Introduction

Cybersecurity has become one of the most critical challenges for modern enterprises, particularly in New Zealand, where regulatory expectations, customer trust, and global cyber threats converge. The 2023 Latitude Financial data breach highlights the severe consequences of inadequate data governance, excessive retention of personal information, and insufficient oversight; demonstrating that not only the financial and reputational damage organisations can suffer but also the long-term harm to individuals whose personal information is misused.

In our report, we applied the ESRM model to the Latitude Financial case scenario. By doing so, it will ensure that organisations can move away from a reactive, “it won’t happen to us” mindset and adopt a proactive, business-aligned strategy that reduces exposure to threats and ensures resilience.

The report will proceed in three parts: an overview of the ESRM model, its application to the Latitude’s case, and ethical practices under the New Zealand ITP Code of Ethics. The findings and recommendations will provide insights for New Zealand enterprises seeking to improve their cybersecurity risk management, safeguard customer trust, and meet regulatory expectations in a fast-changing digital world.

Overview of ESRM

ESRM Overview

ESRM links security risks to business goals by including system security in business policy. It promotes collaboration between cybersecurity teams and stakeholders, who own and manage critical assets essential for business continuity. Traditionally, teams relied on technical controls like MFA and firewalls without stakeholder input. ESRM instead promotes joint, data-driven decision-making, where cybersecurity priorities risks and stakeholders manage them (Meyer, 2023). Effective recovery requires securing all endpoints against insider, hacker and third-party threats. Protecting customer data; the company's most valuable asset is vital to prevent downtime and reputational harm (CISCO, 2023).

ESRM Pillars

Key foundations of a strong ESRM policy for Latitude Finance include:

Risk based approach: Assets are prioritised by likelihood and business impact ensuring security supports goals. Latitude failed to identify customer data as a high-value, high-risk asset. Refer to Appendix A for risk matrix.

Stakeholder engagement: Cybersecurity and stakeholders must co-operate, share responsibility and align decisions to goals. ESRM ensures risk is assessed for all departments. For Latitude, greater collaboration would have lowered the risk.

Continuous improvement & transparency: ESRM requires regular updating to match changing cyber climate and past mistakes. This includes monitoring systems for unusual activities, checking Third-party access credentials.

Data driven decision making: Quantitative data analysis reduces mitigation risk and avoids use of personal judgement. Latitude failed to use quantitative analysis leading to bad decisions.

Governance: Weak data retention policy can affect regulatory compliance which is the Stakeholders responsibility. Latitude stored obsolete data, failing to keep and review a register of unused data (Kollmorgen, 2023).

ESRM Life Cycle

Implementing ESRM at Latitude Finance has 4 main phases. Refer to Appendix B for ESRM diagram.

1. Identify and prioritise assets: Latitude's assets include data, physical devices, human resources, reputation, brand, computer systems, intellectual property, suppliers (cloud services), vendors and service providers (ISPs).

2. Identifying and Prioritising Risks: Once assets are identified, prioritise by risk, value and financial impact. Assess threats (malware, phishing, ransomware, supply chain) and vulnerabilities for each critical asset. Evaluate risks by likelihood, business impact, potential threats.

3. Mitigating Prioritised Risks: After risks are identified and prioritised, strategies are developed using security controls. Latitude can:

- **Accept** risk and business impact.

- **Avoid** risk by changing activities using controls (e.g., multi-factor authentication, firewalls, employee training, server protection).
- **Transfer** risk to a third party by outsourcing or having cyber insurance.
- **Mitigate** risk with policies to reduce potential impact.

4. Continuous Improvement: The ESRM is ongoing monitoring of new threats, reviewing security controls and adjusting policies to remain resilient. Latitude should create a cyber risk culture to increase awareness.

ESRM Principles

Principles Latitude Finance should follow when using ESRM:

- Partnership with leadership: The cybersecurity team must partner with stakeholders to manage risk and support ESRM. Without collaboration, risks remain disconnected from business goals as Liz MacPherson, NZ Privacy Commissioner said Latitude's "She'll be right" attitude reflects complacency. ESRM enhances accountability, continuous improvement and strategic integration.
- Holistic view: Latitude must address digital, human, and physical threats by educating stakeholders on vulnerabilities, business impact and mitigation.
- Transparency and Governance: Open communication ensures security is part of business decisions. ESRM supports compliance with GDPR, NZ Privacy Act 2020, and NIST. Latitude failed to address compliance gaps that increased reputational risk and ignored that privacy policies build customer trust.
- Business driven decision-making: Since not all risks can be eliminated, stakeholders prioritise risks based on business impact, allocating resources to the assets with the highest potential effect.

ESRM Goals

The goals of ESRM at Latitude are to align security to business policy, allowing proactive defense, resilience and compliance with NZ Privacy Act 2020. ESRM provides a clear plan while strengthening incident response.

- Real-Time Threat Detection and Response: Tools like MFA or SIEM help detect suspicious activity as most breaches occur through employee credentials (Vaughan, 2023).
- Third-Party Vendor Risk Management: Many attacks come via compromised third-party devices. ESRM monitors and checks vendor access to reduce network risks and lateral attacks.
- Incident Response and Communication: ESRM improves communication with customers after breaches. Latitude's slow and vague communication to customers (Stock, 2023) caused extra work for employees and loss of customer trust (Stock, 2023; Barrett, 2023).
- Data Retention: ESRM requires a Data Retention and Disposal Register to track data storage times and deletion of old data.

ESRM Benefits

Benefits for Latitude Finance:

- Risk management strategies: Align security risks with business objectives creating robust system security.

- Resource allocation: Better resource allocation to critical assets and staff training, with accountability.
- Communication: Improved collaboration with stakeholders, building customer trust and brand protection.
- Compliance: Supports GDPR, NIST, and NZ Privacy Act 2020 compliance, reducing penalties, reputational damage and improving recovery.
- Informed decision making: Data driven decisions based on quantitative analysis.
- Third Party Checks: Reduces vulnerabilities from external vendors through monitoring.

Implementing ESRM

Enterprise Security Risk Management (ESRM) is a holistic approach to protect people, critical assets, and operations from all threats that an organisation faces (AlertMedia, 2025). Instead of looking at security as just a technical or compliance function, it focuses on what the business values most, ensuring executives own risk and satisfy the New Zealand Privacy Act 2020. By applying the ESRM model, we can manage Latitude’s security risks, which is well-suited for the New Zealand enterprise environment.

In ESRM’s life cycle, aligned with NIST framework we follow four steps:

Step	ESRM steps	NIST CSF steps
1	Identify and Prioritise Assets	Identify
2	Identify and Prioritise Risks	Identify
3	Mitigate prioritise risks	Detect and Protect
4	Improve and Advance	Respond and Recover

Table 1: ESRM lifecycle aligned with NIST CSF

Identify and Prioritise assets

Firstly, the cybersecurity team will identify all the enterprise assets that need to be protected from potential risks in organisations.

After all the assets are identified, the team will identify the stakeholders who are involved in making risk decisions for those assets. Once stakeholders are identified, the team will work with all of them to understand the impact and importance of each asset to prioritise them.

We have following assets and stakeholders that could affect Latitude's business:

Priority	Asset	Stakeholders involved
1	Customer Personal Information	- Customers - Regulators - Board and Executives - IT & Security Teams - Third-Party Service Providers
2	Customer Trust and Reputation	- Board and Executives - Customers and Public - Shareholders or Investors - Media - Business Partners
3	Regulatory and Legal Compliance	- Regulators - Legal Officers - Board and Executives - Auditors - Customers
4	Operational IT Systems	- IT Operations Team - Business Units (e.g. customer service) - Customers - Vendors or Suppliers - Executives
5	Employees or Insiders	- Employees - Human Resource Team - IT/Security Managers - Board and Executives - Regulators
6	Financial Assets and Records	- Customers - Finance Department - Regulators - Shareholders or Investors - Business Partners

Table 2: List of Latitude's assets and priority

#1. Customer Personal Information

The main cause of the crisis. Over one million past and present New Zealand drivers' licenses and passports were exposed. Many of these records are over ten years old, and some are even over 18 years old, which could raise questions about why they have been retained for so long. This asset is considered as most critical as it is required for financial services, highly sensitive under NZ's Privacy Act 2020 and directly linked to regulatory fines, lawsuits, fraud, and public trust.

#2. Customer Trust & Reputation

The breach damaged Latitude's reputation and reduced customer confidence. It determines the long-term survival of the enterprise, as without trust, the business will not be able to continue. Once trust is lost, it could cause long-term brand damage and loss of market share.

#3. Regulatory & Legal Compliance

Mandatory under the New Zealand Privacy Act 2020. Failing to resolve data breaches can lead to facing enforcement action, heavy financial penalties, reputational harm, lawsuits and in the worst case, close down operations.

#4. Operational IT Systems

Needed for service delivery. Without them, business operations will stop. Service disruptions may cause short-term pain such as revenue loss and customer dissatisfaction, but are recoverable, so not the highest priority.

#5. Employee / Insider Knowledge

Staff are vulnerable to phishing and negligence, and some may exploit customer data for personal benefit. If a staff member with highly privileged access to the system is affected by these vulnerabilities, it could cause significant damage to the enterprise's operation.

They are manageable through access controls, monitoring, and training. Therefore, less priority.

Identify and Prioritise security risks

The next step is risk assessment. Engaging with the stakeholders, the cybersecurity team will identify threats and vulnerabilities associated with each asset, considering both internal and external factors.

Once the risks are identified, they are prioritised based on their likelihood and impact on the business's assets. Refer to Appendix A for the risk matrix.

We can identify following risks from Latitude's case:

Priority	Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Assets at risk
1	Excessive data retention	Critical	Critical	Customer Personal Information (drivers' licences, passports and other records)
2	External Cyberattack	High	High	Operational IT Systems (IT systems, databases, customer portals)
3	Reputational damage and Loss of Customer Trust	High	High	Customer Trust and Reputation
4	Regulatory non-compliance	Medium	High	Regulatory and Legal Compliance
5	Operational disruption	Medium	Medium	Business continuity and service delivery
6	Insider Threat	Low	Medium	Customer Personal Information, Financial Assets and Records

Table 3: Risks and Priority

#1. Excessive data retention

- **Threat:** Cybercriminal intrusion.

- **Vulnerability:** Retention of records up to 18 years old without business need.
- **Impact:** Massive breach scale, non-compliance with Privacy Act 2020, reputational harm.

Most critical risk. This was the root cause of the severity of the Latitude breach, raising both reputational and compliance issues. Retaining personal data far beyond its lawful requirement led to exposure in the event of a breach.

#2. External Cyberattack

- **Threat:** Cybercriminals using persistent threats.
- **Vulnerability:** Weak monitoring, insufficient detection controls.
- **Impact:** Exposure of millions of records, business disruption, financial loss.

High-risk cyber attackers gained unauthorised access to Latitude's large volumes of old, sensitive customer data due to weak system defences and exposed all retained data.

#3. Reputational damage and Loss of Customer Trust

- **Threat:** Public and media backlash.
- **Vulnerability:** Poor crisis communication, slow customer notifications.
- **Impact:** Long-term loss of customers, investor confidence, and partnerships.

High risk as reputation is one of the most valuable but fragile assets; once lost, hard to rebuild and may cause customers to move to other competitors.

#4. Regulatory non-compliance

- **Threat:** Privacy Commissioner investigations, lawsuits, penalties.
- **Vulnerability:** Failure to enforce data minimisation and retention policies.

- **Impact:** Fines, enforcement action, potential restrictions on operating.

Medium to high risk. Breach showed a clear violation of compliance expectations. Failing to meet privacy law requirements can lead to severe penalties by regulators in New Zealand and Australia.

#5. Operational disruption

- **Threat:** System downtime due to incident response.
- **Vulnerability:** Lack of redundancy, limited continuity planning.
- **Impact:** Customers unable to access services, lost revenue.

Medium risk. Significant impact, but temporary and can be fixed over time.

Mitigate prioritised risks

The next step is to develop risk treatment plans to address the root cause of each prioritised risk. There are four types of strategies, including Avoidance, Mitigation, Acceptance, and Transference. Refer to Appendix C. These risk treatment plans are then embedded into existing business processes, and all relevant teams and units are to be informed of risk management responsibilities.

For Latitude's incident, we can apply the following strategies:

Risk	Mitigation Strategies
Excessive Data Retention	- Data minimisation and retention policies - Automated deletion of customer records beyond business or legal need - Encryption of all sensitive data
External Cyberattack	- Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) - Least privilege - Regular patching - Deploy Security Information and Event Management (SIEM) for real-time threat detection
Reputational damage and Loss of Customer Trust	- Crisis communication plan with pre-approved messages for customers and regulators - Offer credit monitoring and fraud protection to affected customers - Publish transparency reports after incidents
Regulatory Non-Compliance	- Appoint a Data Protection Officer - Conduct annual compliance audits - Regular training for staff on Privacy Act 2020 obligations
Operational Disruption	- Implement business continuity and disaster recovery plans - Regular backups - Conduct tabletop exercises to test recovery speed
Insider Threat	- Least privilege access to sensitive systems - User activity monitoring and anomaly detection - Provide ethical training

Table 4: Mitigation strategies for risks

Continuous Improvement

After the mitigation, ESRM requires risks to be reassessed regularly. Processes to regularly monitor, audit, report, and update are essential to adapt to changing threats and adjust if needed.

We can apply the following for continuous monitoring for Latitude risks:

Risk	Monitoring
Excessive Data Retention	- Annual retention audits - Board reporting on data minimisation
External Cyberattack	- Monthly penetration tests - SOC reports to executives
Reputational damage and Loss of Customer Trust	- Post-incident surveys - Brand sentiment tracking, stakeholder feedback
Regulatory Non-Compliance	- Quarterly compliance reports - Regulator engagement
Operational Disruption	- Recovery time objectives measured and reviewed after each test
Insider Threat	- Quarterly insider threat reviews - Human Resource audit logs

Table 5: Continuous monitoring of risks

Applying Ethical Practices

Introduction to the Ethical Framework

Cybersecurity is not only a technical science, but also a field in which decisions directly affect society, its rights, security, and trust. In New Zealand, IT professionals are required to comply with the **ITP Code of Ethics**, a framework that essentially establishes principles of integrity, competence, responsibility, fairness, and sustainability. This framework further strengthens the stance that professionals must take toward their employers, clients, regulations, and society in general.

The example of the Latitude Financial ruling shows how the lack of an ethical culture of data protection and cybersecurity increased the impact of the breach. Retaining data for almost twenty years, without any legal or business basis, not only violated privacy regulations, but also the core value of professional responsibility.

Principle of Integrity

The principle of integrity emphasises acting honestly and clearly when handling information. In the ESRM framework, the principle is equivalent to the mandate to explicitly inform the customer about the purpose of data collection, retention period, and protection measures used.

In the example considered, Latitude did not observe this standard, as it stored sensitive information long after it was reasonable or necessary. Ethical use of ESRM requires data minimisation policies and systematic deletion of obsolete data. This would have greatly reduced the amount of information exposed during the attack and, as a result, the impact on the individuals involved.

Principle of Competence

The code of ethics requires IT professionals to be competent and diligent, using best practices and continuously updating their knowledge. In an environment where information retention is accepted as a critical risk vector, the lack of appropriate policies reflects a lack of organisational competence.

From an ESRM perspective, competence would consist of conducting periodic risk assessment tests and implementing appropriate technical and administrative controls. An example would be to incorporate routine compliance audits under the Privacy Act of 2020, as well as security tests to identify vulnerabilities in the data storage infrastructure.

Principle of Responsibility

Professional responsibility is not only about fulfilling an organisation's mandate but also includes protecting the public interest. Personal data is highly sensitive, and its privacy is an ethical obligation to society.

In this scenario, the action of storing unnecessary information placed millions of citizens at risk of fraud and identity theft, acting directly against the principle of responsibility. Within the ESRM framework, responsibility becomes the integration of cybersecurity into corporate governance and direct oversight by the board of directors.

Principle of Respect and Fairness

Respect for customers includes protecting their privacy and handling their data in an appropriate and proportionate manner. Keeping passports, licences, and financial records for such long periods of time without informed consent or clear necessity represented a lack of respect for the rights of its customers.

Applying the ESRM, this principle is implemented through clear consent policies, periodic reviews of stored data, and clear communication processes. Ethics becomes the

fundamental requirement for ensuring that information management is viewed as fair and respectful among those who entrust their data to an organisation.

Principle of Sustainability and Social Welfare

The ITP Code of Ethics also decrees the obligation to contribute to a sustainable digital ecosystem. A company that manages data without ethical principles undermines trust in the national financial and digital system. Each major security breach erodes confidence in online services and strengthens citizens' skepticism about sharing data.

ESRM supports the sustainability of work for the development of a proactive risk management cycle, minimising the possibility of incidents that could have a systemic impact on society.

Connection between Ethics and Legal Compliance

Professional ethics are closely linked to legal obligations. In New Zealand, the **Privacy Act 2020** establishes principles of data retention, minimisation, and transparency. Although mere compliance with the law is not enough, the ESMR requires organisations to go beyond legal compliance and embrace an ethical culture of security whose strategic focus is the protection of customer data.

Findings and Recommendations

Akshay

The Latitude Finance breach resulted from weak data retention policy and governance, highlighting the need for stronger security policy that aligns with business objectives to protect critical assets. Latitude's data retention increased risk of attack, the privacy commission says, "it is the sleeping giant of data security". Prioritising risks, making data-driven decisions, collaboration between cybersecurity and stakeholders improves incident response, customer trust and reputation. Implementing ESRM will reduce vulnerabilities, strengthen governance, create a cybersecurity culture and resilience to secure Latitude's future business.

Alex

Just because the risks were resolved does not mean risk management is over. No security is perfect, and hackers will continue to evolve and persistently attack our enterprises' systems. Without continuous improvement, our enterprises will be exposed to even greater data breaches in the future.

While Latitude should be monitored by Governance and Risk Analysts, they should build resilience through continuous monitoring and assessing potential risks and use strategies to respond to those risks. By embedding continuous improvement into operations, Latitude will avoid the complacency that often precedes breaches.

Luis

Based on the conclusions of the Latitude case and the practice of the ESRM under the **ITP code of ethics**, various ethical recommendations can be formulated to help frame data management in this type of organisation.

First, the principle of data minimisation should be applied as an ethical and operational standard, in order to ensure that personal data is retained only for as long as strictly necessary and solely for legitimate purposes.

At the same time, companies must increase transparency by frequently reporting to customers on how their data is collected, protected, and stored, and only for a specified period of time.

Another important recommendation is to incorporate ethics into company management by creating security committees with the participation of senior management, to ensure that the company's strategic decision-making on risk management includes an ethical perspective and not just a technical one.

Similarly, staff training on ethical cybersecurity standards should be ongoing, so that data management is a common concern for all members of the company.

Finally, independent and regular audits should be recommended to determine not only compliance with legislation, but also compliance with ethical data protection standards, in order to strengthen public confidence and the soundness of the company.

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Appendices

Appendix A



(AlertMedia, 2025)

Appendix B



(The ESRM Life Cycle)

(Sunarso, 2019)

Appendix C



(HYPERPROOF TEAM, 2025)